

Section 2: The Road

La strada - Types of Roads and Road-related Terms

1. The Three Core Definitions

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Strada	Road	Public area designed for the movement of pedestrians, vehicles and animals . Includes sidewalks (urban) or shoulders (non-urban), bike lanes and carriageways
Carreggiata	Carriageway	Part of the road for vehicle circulation . Does NOT include sidewalks, shoulders, bike lanes, lay-bys (piazzole di sosta) or emergency lanes. Can be one-way (senso unico) or two-way (doppio senso)
Corsia	Lane	Longitudinal division of the carriageway for a single line of vehicles

2. Pedestrian & Edge Areas

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Attraversamento pedonale	Pedestrian crossing (zebra crossing)	Area of the carriageway marked by white stripes where pedestrians can cross safely
Banchina	Shoulder / verge	Strip of ground along the edge of the carriageway. Used for emergency stops or to separate the carriageway from adjacent areas
Marciapiede	Sidewalk / pavement	Paved space along the sides of a road, for pedestrians
Salvagente	Pedestrian refuge island	Raised or marked area within the carriageway acting as a refuge for pedestrians, often near intersections
Isola di traffico	Traffic island	Raised or marked area within the carriageway to manage traffic flow , often found in roundabouts

3. Intersections & Crossings

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Intersezione	Intersection	Point where two or more roads cross ; can be at the same level or with various traffic configurations
Intersezione a raso	At-grade intersection	Crossing where two or more roads meet at the same level

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Intersezione a livelli sfalsati	Grade-separated intersection	Intersection of roads at different heights / levels (e.g. overpasses)
Passaggio a livello	Level crossing	Intersection between a road and a railway on the same level
Passo carrabile	Driveway access	Private access connecting a property to the road; marked by a specific sign (parking forbidden in front of it)

4. Zones & Special Areas

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Zona a traffico limitato (ZTL)	Limited Traffic Zone	Area where vehicle access is restricted at certain times to reduce traffic and improve air quality
Area pedonale	Pedestrian area	Urban space reserved exclusively for pedestrians ; vehicles cannot enter
Pista ciclabile	Bike lane / cycle path	Path separated from the carriageway for bicycle traffic
Centro abitato	Built-up area	Built area with at least 25 buildings , like a neighborhood within a city
Parcheggio	Parking	Area designated for the parking (sosta) of vehicles
Zona di preselezione	Pre-selection zone	Area of the road before an intersection where vehicles must position in specific lanes based on the direction they intend to take

5. Lane Types (Corsie)

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Corsia di marcia	Driving lane	Main lane for vehicles going the same direction. Stay here unless overtaking or exiting
Corsia di sorpasso	Overtaking lane	Lane used specifically for overtaking slower vehicles; usually on the left . Return to the driving lane after
Corsia di accelerazione	Acceleration lane	Lane to speed up when entering a motorway, to match traffic flow before merging
Corsia di decelerazione	Deceleration lane	Lane to slow down safely when exiting a motorway, before an exit or toll booth
Corsia riservata	Reserved lane	Reserved for specific vehicles (buses, taxis, emergency). Regular vehicles prohibited

Italian	English	Meaning / Notes
Corsia di emergenza	Emergency lane	On the far right of a motorway; only for emergencies, breakdowns or emergency services. Driving in it is forbidden
Corsia centrale	Central lane	Shared lane often in urban areas for turning left , usable by vehicles from both directions

6. Road Classifications (by type)

Italian	English	Key features
Autostrada	Motorway / Highway	Carriageways separated by an impassable divider ; at least 2 lanes per carriageway ; service areas, emergency lanes, accel./decel. lanes; no at-grade crossings ; specific vehicle categories only
Strada extraurbana principale	Main extra-urban road	Like a motorway (separated carriageways, ≥ 2 lanes per direction) but may allow access to private properties
Strada extraurbana secondaria	Secondary extra-urban road	Usually a single carriageway with at least one lane per direction and shoulders. E.g. a provincial road through rural areas
Strada urbana di scorrimento	Urban through road	Urban roads with carriageways separated by a divider , ≥ 2 lanes per direction, often sidewalks and public-transport lanes. May have traffic-light intersections
Strada urbana di quartiere	Urban neighborhood road	Residential roads, single carriageway, at least two lanes; often allow parking along the road

Key Points to Memorize

- **STRADA** = everything; **CARREGGIATA** = vehicle part only; **CORSIA** = one lane.
- Carriageway does NOT include: sidewalks, shoulders, bike lanes, lay-bys, emergency lanes.
- **Centro abitato** = built-up area with **at least 25 buildings** (common exam number!).
- **A raso** = same level; **a livelli sfalsati** = different levels.
- **Passaggio a livello** = road + railway; **Passo carrabile** = private driveway entrance.
- **Autostrada**: impassable divider, ≥ 2 lanes/carriageway, NO at-grade crossings.
- Driving in the **emergency lane (corsia di emergenza)** is forbidden except for real emergencies.
- **Salvagente** = refuge for pedestrians; **Isola di traffico** = manages traffic flow (roundabouts).